DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION IN PROJECT TEAMS

How D&I Practices Shape Project Outcomes

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Group 12

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Abstract

This report looks at how diversity and inclusion (D&I) within project teams can influence project outcomes. Most of the existing discussion around D&I tends to frame it as an ethical or corporate responsibility issue, however this report takes a more performance-focused view and treats D&I as something that directly shapes how a project ends up performing. The analysis is organised around three themes that come up consistently in the literature, these being innovation, risk identification and management, and team coherence and psychological safety. Across all three themes, the evidence points to the same thing, that diversity on its own does not automatically lead to better outcomes, and that trust, psychological safety and active management are what determine whether diversity actually helps or hurts a project. The argument is then grounded in two contrasting case studies. The Uber case shows what happens when inclusion is missing, where under-representation of women and a culture that dismissed complaints eventually led to reputational damage, leadership departures and significant disruption to project delivery. The London 2012 Olympic Games shows the opposite, where strong governance, coordination and psychological safety allowed a very diverse set of teams, contractors and stakeholders to deliver the project successfully in terms of time, cost and governance. The report finishes with three recommendations for PMs, these being that a diverse team should not be assumed to perform well on its own, that inclusion should be built into how teams are structured and governed from day one, and that project managers should create environments where team members feel safe enough to speak up and raise concerns.

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1 Introduction

Project teams today look quite different from how they did in the past. Globalisation, digital collaboration and the rise of cross-functional organisational structures mean that project teams are now regularly made up of people with very different backgrounds, professional experiences and ways of thinking (PMI, 2020). Alongside this shift, diversity and inclusion (oft referred to in this document as simply D&I) has become a much bigger topic in project management, but is often framed as an ethics or corporate responsibility issue, rather than as something that directly affects how a project performs.

This report is more interested in how D&I shape project performance, rather than whether organisations should be pursuing it in the first place. This matters because research consistently shows that having diversity in a team is not automatically beneficial. Stahl et al. (2010) describe diversity as akin to a double-edged sword, as on one side teams with cultural and cognitive diversity tend to generate broader perspectives and are often better at processing information and solving problems, but on the other they can run into issues with communication, interpersonal conflict and coordination. In other words, whether diversity actually ends up helping or hurting a project depends largely on whether effective inclusion is in place or not (Horwitz and Horwitz, 2007; Van Knippenberg, De Dreu and Homan, 2004).

Before moving on, it is worth briefly defining some key terms. Diversity here refers to the presence of differences within a team, including visible characteristics like gender, ethnicity and nationality, as well as less visible attributes such as disciplinary background, cognitive style and professional experience (Harrison and Klein, 2007). Inclusion refers to the extent to which individuals feel valued, psychologically safe and able to contribute to team processes and group decision making, and in project settings it is operationalised through leadership behaviour, communication structures and conflict management. Outcomes are assessed through conventional project indicators such as time, cost, scope and quality, along with broader measures such as stakeholder satisfaction, innovation output and team cohesion.

The analysis section focuses on three key areas in the literature where D&I has been shown to influence project performance; these being innovation and creativity, risk identification and management, and team coherence and psychological safety. Across all three themes, the evidence points in the same direction, showing that diversity can lead to either improved or impaired performance, and that it is inclusion which ends up determining which of the two a project actually gets (Mata et al., 2021; Dacre et al., 2021; Wax et al., 2024; Edmondson, 1999).

To ground these arguments in practice, the report compares two contrasting projects: the works of Uber, where exclusion and systemic marginalisation have in the past led to organisational and delivery failures (Fowler, 2017; Covington and Burling LLP, 2017), and the London 2012 Olympic Games, where inclusive governance and coordinated stakeholder management contributed directly to successful delivery

(National Audit Office, 2012). The comparison is designed to identify the distinguishing factors between the two cases, rather than catalogue similarities.

2 Analysis

The following analysis examines three key areas through which D&I impacts project outcomes: innovation, risk identification and management, and team coherence and psychological safety. Across each theme, the evidence suggests that the impact of D&I on project outcomes is not straightforward, and that the conditions surrounding it determine whether it helps or hinders project performance.

2.1 Innovation

There is growing evidence linking D&I to innovation in project teams, however this relationship is actually more complicated than it first appears. Gardiner, Alkhudary and Druon (2022) make this clear in their review of project based organisations, finding that the link between diversity and innovation only holds when inclusion is actively built into how a project team is run.

Looking at the bigger picture, organisations with proper D&I initiatives consistently show higher levels of innovation and are better at responding to change. Chinenye Gbemisola Okatta, Funmilayo Aribidesi Ajayi, and Olufunke Olawale (2024) back this up as their meta-analysis highlights that organisations who prioritise diversity and inclusion tend to experience several benefits, one of them being enhanced innovation. However, this report is speaking about organisations and not specifically about project teams. With that said it still gives us a useful starting point for understanding how D&I can drive innovation.

The question is how diversity leads to innovation in practice. Van Knippenberg, De Dreu and Homan (2004) offers a strong explanation, arguing that diversity leads to greater sharing and discussion of task relevant ideas, knowledge and perspectives amongst team members. In other words, when a team is made up of people with different backgrounds and experiences, there is more information that a project team can draw from whilst solving problems or whilst generating ideas. This matters because it provides the link connecting diversity to better outcomes, rather than just assuming that having diversity in project teams leads to this link.

Looking specifically at project teams, the evidence shows that diversity and inclusion does actually lead to better innovation, however the way that it works is more complicated than simply creating Diverse teams. Mata et al (2021), studied 270 members across IT project teams and found that knowledge diversity and value diversity both positively enhance project performance including innovation, however this only happens crucially when trust is present in the team. In other words, diverse project teams only become more innovative when team members trust each other enough to share ideas and take in the different knowledge that diversity brings. Without these factors, diversity doesn’t automatically equal better outcomes (Mata et al., 2021). This is backed up by PMI (2020), whose survey of project professionals

found that 88% believe that diverse project teams increase a project's value and importantly PMI links this to innovation, stating that drawing from a wide range of backgrounds and experiences drives innovative thinking that might otherwise be missed in project settings

That said, diverse teams do not always produce better outcomes. Horwitz and Horwitz (2007) highlight that when team members hold very different viewpoints, it can take longer to reach agreement, which can lead to conflicts within the team that damage outcomes rather than improve them. This reinforces what Mata et al (2021) found, that without the right conditions in place, particularly trust, diversity can become a source of friction rather than a driver of innovation.

Overall, the evidence suggests that diversity and inclusion have real potential to drive innovation in project teams, however the evidence consistently shows that inclusion and trust must be present within the team for that innovation potential to be realised in practice. In project management terms this matters because innovative teams are better equipped to deliver solutions that meet stakeholder expectations, adapt to scope changes, and deliver value beyond the initial project brief.

2.2 Risk Identification and Management

One area where the literature suggests that D&I has a particularly direct impact on project outcomes is risk identification and management, however evidence here suggests a more complicated picture than simply saying diverse teams are better at managing risks. Dacre et al (2021) uses interviews with project management professionals across multiple sectors, they argue that diverse teams are better equipped to spot risks than teams with less diversity because having different perspectives means that assumptions will get challenged that may otherwise just be taken for granted. However, it is worth mentioning that Dacre et al (2021) findings are based on interviews rather than numerical data, which means that the results may not apply equally across all project types and industries.

The picture becomes more complicated when conflict is introduced. Wu et al (2019) studied 246 professionals on construction projects and found that whilst diversity positively affects project performance, conflict can significantly weaken this relationship. Their research highlights two types of conflict emerging in diverse project teams. The first is disagreements about how work should be done, which could be useful for project performance as having a diverse range of ways to do things could lead to a more efficient solutions being generated. The second is interpersonal conflicts between team members, which can and will damage the project team as well as the projects outcome. What's interesting is that the same diversity that helps a team spot more risk also can create internal tensions that can stop the team from acting on those risks effectively.

This is where Farid (2021) comes in, identifying trust as what allows diverse project teams to move past this tension. Studying a complex organisational change project, Farid (2021) highlights that when trust is present in a project team, it becomes easier for members to build working relationships, communicate openly and manage risks

more effectively. Something also worth mentioning is that as noted in Farid (2021), having a diverse range of skills and backgrounds in a project team can make trust harder to build in the first place, which means project managers cannot assume that it will develop on its own.

This has direct implications for how project teams are managed in practice. If diverse perspectives are present in a team, but team members do not feel able to raise concerns openly, then risks that could have been identified earlier have been left to escalate. Equally, if conflict within a diverse team is left unmanaged, the team's ability to act on the risks that it identifies is then weakened. This means that for project managers, creating conditions where diverse team members can speak up and work through disagreements is not optional as it is essential for effective risk management. These findings suggest that inclusion, in the form of trust and open communication is what enables diverse project teams to manage risk effectively rather than being weakened by it.

Overall, the evidence suggests that diversity does improve a project team's ability to identify and manage risks, but conflict and trust are what determine whether those benefits show up in practice, making them just as important to project outcomes as diversity itself.

2.3 Team Coherence and Psychological Safety

A recurring concern in the literature is whether diversity undermines the cohesion that project teams need to function effectively. Güver and Motschnig (2017) found through their review of 122 studies that diverse teams can struggle with cohesion because of lower cooperation, more conflicts and ineffective communication within the diverse team. Mello and Delise (2015) reinforce this, finding that without any conflict management diversity can directly damage a team's cohesion.

However, the evidence also shows that with the right conditions in place, diversity can actually strengthen cohesion rather than weaken it. Mello and Delise (2015) found that when conflict management is present within a diverse team, the teams members are able to openly address their disagreements and develop cohesion as a result. Lee, Chae and Chung (2025) build on this idea, whilst challenging the traditional view of diversity and cohesion being opposing forces and finding that when properly managed, the two can truly work together to drive stronger team performance.

What comes through from the literature is that psychological safety plays a big role in making this work. Wax et al (2024) investigated this by studying 143 self-assembled project teams, some made up of people with different backgrounds and some where everyone came from the same backgrounds. What they found was that when psychological safety is low, it can impact people on diverse teams harder than those on less diverse teams, particularly when it comes to how much they are learning. This highlights that if people on diverse teams don't feel safe enough to speak up or be themselves, the negative effects are worse than they would be on a team where everyone might share the same or similar backgrounds. This is important as it suggests that diverse teams don't just benefit from psychological safety, they need it more, and

without it the benefits that can come with having a diverse project team can be lost entirely. It is worth noting that Wax et al (2024) did use a student sample rather than a workplace sample. However, the core idea that diverse teams have a greater need for psychological safety is consistent with what the rest of this analysis has shown, particularly the role of trust in sections 2.1 and 2.2, and it reinforces the argument that diversity without the right conditions in place can do more harm than good. In this sense, psychological safety can be understood as a key part of inclusion, and one that diverse project teams can depend on a lot.

Overall, the evidence suggests that diversity and inclusion have a complex relationship with team coherence in project settings. When inclusion is actively managed through conflict resolution, psychological safety and collaborative practices, diversity can strengthen the project team's cohesion, however without that active management diversity within the project team can risk creating a fractured team environment that will lead to poor project outcomes.

2.4 Summary of Analysis

Across all three themes, the evidence points to the same conclusion. D&I creates the potential for stronger project outcomes through broader perspectives, better risk identification and more resilient teams, but that potential is only realised when trust, psychological safety and active management are present. Without these conditions, D&I can just as easily become a source of conflict, miscommunication and poor performance. The following case studies examine how this plays out in practice, comparing an organisation where these conditions were absent with one where they were embedded into how the project was run.

3 Case Studies and Discussion

3.1 Case Study 1: Uber

The Uber case is one of the clearest examples of how neglecting D&I can damage organisational performance and project delivery. Although Uber was growing quickly commercially, its internal culture had serious problems that became public in February 2017, when engineer Susan Fowler published a personal account of persistent sexual harassment, inaction by managers and inconsistent HR processes (Fowler, 2017). Complaints from women were often dismissed, particularly when perpetrators were seen as high performers, which showed that Uber's culture was prioritising individuals over the wellbeing of the rest of its employees (Fowler, 2017).

The scale of underrepresentation at Uber made things considerably worse. Women constituted only 33% of the total workforce, falling to 22% in leadership roles and as low as 15% in technical positions (Steinmetz and Vella, 2017). When so few diverse voices exist at decision-making levels, organisations lose the ability to identify ethical and reputational risks early, precisely the kind of oversight that could have prevented Uber's crisis from reaching the scale it did (Turi et al., 2022).

Once Fowler's allegations went public, Uber's Board commissioned an independent investigation led by former US Attorney General Eric Holder, which identified widespread cultural and governance failures across leadership, HR and D&I functions and recommended major structural reforms (Covington and Burling LLP, 2017). At least twenty employees were dismissed and several senior leaders left the company, including CEO Travis Kalanick. This was followed by multiple lawsuits, regulatory scrutiny and considerable reputational damage globally, pulling the organisation's attention and resources away from where they needed to be focused (Williams, 2017).

The academic literature helps explain why the consequences were so far-reaching. When inclusion is missing within an organisation, employee trust breaks down, and with it goes the collaboration and engagement that project teams rely on (Hoang, Suh and Sabharwal, 2022). At Uber, the way women and minority voices were marginalised created an environment where serious risks were allowed to escalate without being challenged, which is consistent with what happens when organisations fail to make use of the perspectives a diverse workforce brings (Turi et al., 2022).

What is interesting here is that none of what happened was actually unforeseeable. Uber's crisis was the result of years of inaction, not some sudden cultural breakdown (Williams, 2017). The consistently low representation of women in leadership had been limiting diversity of thought at the top of the organisation for a long time, which effectively set the conditions for what eventually happened (Ramseook-Munhurrun et al., 2023).

After all of this, the newly appointed CEO Dara Khosrowshahi committed to meaningful cultural reform, bringing in a revised code of conduct, mandatory harassment training, upgraded reporting systems and moving the D&I function so that it reported directly to the CEO (Covington and Burling LLP, 2017). This shift reflects a growing recognition that D&I is not just an ethical obligation, but more of a basic condition for an organisation to function effectively over time (Platania et al., 2025).

Overall, the Uber case serves as a warning. Failures in D&I carry real consequences for organisations, ranging from damaged reputation and loss of trust to leadership instability, legal issues and disrupted project delivery. For any project-based organisation, the takeaway is that inclusive cultures where people feel safe to speak up are not just a nice to have, but something actually needed for effective risk management, innovation and long-term success (Hoang, Suh and Sabharwal, 2022).

3.2 Case Study 2: The 2012 London Olympic Games

The 2012 London Olympics is one of the clearest examples of how diversity and inclusiveness can positively impact the outcomes of large-scale, complex project environments. As a mega project involving multiple organizations, contractors, public institutions and stakeholders, the Olympic Games requires extensive coordination across professional, organizational and cultural boundaries. Despite these challenges, the London 2012 Olympic Games is still widely regarded as a successful project, especially in terms of delivery discipline, cost control and governance effectiveness

(British National Audit Office, 2012). This makes it a valuable case for studying how diversity and inclusiveness can actually improve project performance.

From a conceptual perspective, we can understand the diversity of the London 2012 Olympic Games through the framework proposed by Harrison and Klein (2007). They believe that diversity should be regarded as separation, diversity and difference, not a single concept. Diversity is reflected in the participation of multidisciplinary teams, including engineers, planners, logistics experts, contractors, and public sector personnel with diverse professional backgrounds. There are also obvious differences in hierarchical relationships between main contractors, subcontractors and management agencies. In addition, differences in organizational priorities, professional identity and work culture can also lead to separation. This shows that the diversity of the London 2012 Olympic Games is not only demographic or symbolic, but structural, and different management methods may enhance or weaken project performance (Harrison and Klein, 2007).

The broader literature shows that diversity does not automatically yield positive results. Stahl et al. (2010) described diversity as a double-edged sword. On the one hand, professional and cultural diversity can improve creativity, broaden the scope of information processing, and enhance problem-solving ability. On the other hand, it may also exacerbate interpersonal conflicts, communication barriers and coordination difficulties. In the project environment, these negative effects will directly affect delivery time, cost-effectiveness and risk exposure (Stahl et al., 2010). Therefore, the key question is not whether there is diversity, but whether the project creates conditions that can effectively integrate different views into decision-making and execution.

Against this background, inclusiveness is crucial. Edmondson (1999) defines psychological security as an environment in which individuals feel able to raise concerns, admit mistakes and contribute ideas without worrying about embarrassment or punishment. In a complex project like the 2012 Olympic Games in London, this atmosphere is particularly important, because the successful delivery of the project depends not only on the formal system and schedule, but also on whether members of each team and level are willing to communicate risks and operational issues early. The research of Newman, Donohue and Eva (2017) further supports this view. They find that a sense of psychological security can improve knowledge sharing, learning behavior and team effectiveness. These results are closely related to project management because they affect coordination quality, the speed of problem identification, and the team's ability to handle uncertainty.

The London 2012 Olympic Games shows the active role of these inclusive mechanisms. According to the British National Audit Office (2012), the success of the Olympic Games is due to strong governance, rigorous supervision, and effective stakeholder coordination. Davis and Mackenzie (2014) further explained that the successful hosting of the London 2012 Olympic Games largely depended on system integration, that is, the coordination of multiple organizations and supply chain participants through a clear structure, common goals and collaborative processes. These arrangements reduce the risk of fragmentation or delay due to organizational

complexity. Although these data are not explicitly analyzed in a pluralistic and inclusive language, their research results strongly show that an inclusive management system and an integrated governance structure enable a highly diversified project environment to operate effectively (Davis and McKenzie, 2014; British National Audit Office, 2012).

Leadership also plays an important role in turning diversity into project success. Mueller and Turner (2010) believe that successful project managers need leadership skills such as communication, coordination, emotional intelligence and stakeholder management. These abilities are particularly important at the 2012 London Olympics, because leaders must coordinate multiple organizations, manage conflicting interests, and stay focused under great time pressure. Therefore, effective leadership promotes inclusiveness by ensuring that diverse expertise is directed toward collective decision-making rather than toward conflict.

This directly affects the project's results. First of all, the integration of diversified expertise has improved the problem-solving ability and innovation ability to cope with complex delivery challenges. Secondly, the supervision of open communication and coordination strengthens risk identification and management, reducing the likelihood of key issues being ignored. Third, the governance structure helps balance the interests of all stakeholders, thereby promoting goal consistency, accountability, and the overall stability of the project. These factors help explain why the London 2012 Olympic Games were successful despite the complexity of diversification.

All in all, the London 2012 Olympic Games shows that the impact of diversity on project results depends largely on inclusiveness. Diversification brings both opportunities and risks, which is consistent with the views of Harrison and Klein (2007) and Stahl et al. (2010). However, a sense of security, effective leadership, strong governance and integrated coordination reduces the negative impact of diversity, while enabling the project to benefit from broader expertise and perspectives (Edmondson, 1999; Müller and Turner, 2010; Newman, Donohue and Eva, 2017). Therefore, the case supports the view that diversity itself does not guarantee the success of a project, but when supplemented by true inclusion, it can significantly improve the performance of large-scale, complex projects.

3.3 Comparisons

The comparison between Uber and the 2012 London Olympic Games shows that diversity alone does not determine the project's results. Both have diverse groups, perspectives, and organisational levels, but this diversified management approach yields very different results. At Uber, due to the lack of an inclusive culture, employee complaints are ignored, minority voices are marginalised, and internal risks are escalating. Weak governance and poor leadership have led to reputational damage, employee turnover, legal pressure, and a loss of organisational direction. Instead of benefiting from diversification, Uber has encountered conflicts, mistrust and instability, which have damaged its performance.

In contrast, the 2012 London Olympics demonstrated how diversification became an advantage for the project, supported by strong governance, effective communication,

and coordinated stakeholder management. Expertise in different fields is integrated into decision-making and delivery processes to help the project maintain progress, control costs, and maintain overall stability. Another difference lies in the sense of psychological security. At Uber, employees dare not speak freely, leading to delays in discovering serious problems. At the 2012 London Olympics, a clearer accountability mechanism and more open communication seem to have contributed to earlier problem reporting and more efficient coordination. In general, the key difference between the two cases is not whether there is diversity, but whether an inclusive mechanism has been established to turn diversity into a successful project outcome.

4 Conclusion

4.1 Key Conclusions

This report set out to examine how diversity and inclusion within project teams influences a project's outcome, focusing on how D&I practices shape project performance. Across the analysis, case studies and comparisons, one central finding has emerged consistently, this being that D&I creates the potential for stronger project outcomes, however that potential is only realised when trust, psychological safety and active management are present.

The analysis examined this through three themes. In innovation, knowledge and value diversity both enhance project performance including innovation, however only when trust is present in the team (Mata et al., 2021). In risk identification, diverse teams are better equipped to spot risks because different perspectives mean that assumptions can be challenged, yet conflict within a project team can significantly weaken this relationship (Dacre et al., 2021; Wu et al., 2019). In team coherence, when psychological safety is low it can impact people on diverse teams harder than those on less diverse teams, meaning the benefits of diverse and inclusive teams can be lost entirely (Wax et al., 2024). Across all three themes, the evidence points to the same conclusion, that D&I creates the potential for stronger project outcomes, however without these conditions it can just as easily become a source of conflict, miscommunication and poor performance.

The case studies brought this to life. At Uber, diversity existed but inclusion was not there: complaints were dismissed, minority voices were marginalised and serious risks were allowed to get worse over time (Fowler, 2017; Covington and Burling LLP, 2017). In contrast, the London 2012 Olympic Games showed that strong governance, coordination and supervision allowed diversity to become something that helped the project deliver successfully (National Audit Office, 2012). The key difference between the two was not whether diversity was actually present but how it was managed.

4.2 Recommendations

Based on these findings, three recommendations are put forward. First, project managers should not assume that having a diverse team will automatically lead to better project outcomes. Both the analysis and the Uber case study showed that without the right conditions in place, diversity can become a source of conflict and poor performance rather than a strength (Horwitz and Horwitz, 2007; Fowler, 2017). Second, inclusion should be built into how project teams are structured and governed from day one. London 2012 showed that strong governance, coordination and open communication were what allowed diversity to contribute to successful delivery, whilst Uber showed what happens when these structures are missing (National Audit Office, 2012; Covington and Burling LLP, 2017). Third, project managers should create environments where team members feel safe to speak up, share ideas and raise concerns. The evidence across the analysis and both case studies consistently highlighted that trust and psychological safety are what determine whether diversity helps or hinders a project (Mata et al., 2021; Farid, 2021; Wax et al., 2024; Edmondson, 1999).

Overall, D&I does not automatically guarantee better project outcomes. It *can* drive innovation, improve risk identification, and strengthen team performance, but only when diversity is supported by genuine inclusion, and the right conditions are in place. Without these, D&I can just as easily become a source of conflict, miscommunication and poor project outcomes.

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